

Every Neighborhood Has A Future... And It Doesn't Include Blight

Detroit Blight Removal Task Force Plan

May 2014

"Nothing will ever be attempted
if all possible objections
must first be overcome."
–Samuel Johnson

"We can easily forgive a child
who is afraid of the dark;
the real tragedy of life
is when men are afraid of the light."
–Socrates

"Everything should be made
as simple as possible,
but not simpler."
–Albert Einstein

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A MESSAGE FROM THE CHAIRS

There are many large-scale difficult challenges in Detroit. Education, crime and jobs highlight the top of the list. However, it is our strong belief that unless and until we eradicate the malignant disease of blight from our city, it will be near impossible to make significant progress in those areas or on any other serious issue that faces our home town.

Blight is a cancer. Blight sucks the soul out of anyone who gets near it, let alone those who are unfortunate enough to live with it all around them. Blight is radioactive. It is contagious. Blight serves as a venue that attracts criminals and crime. It is a magnet for arsonists. Blight is a dangerous place for firefighters and other emergency workers to perform their duties.

Blight is also a symbol. It is a symbol of all that is wrong and all that has gone wrong for too many decades in the once thriving world-class city of Detroit. The proliferation of blight throughout Detroit has not only become a negative symbol for those who live near or around it but it has also become negatively synonymous with the City of Detroit itself; not just locally but in newspapers, television, on-line and in virtually every other medium worldwide.

The phrase 'ruin-porn' did not emerge accidentally. It emerged because it is rooted in the truth that tens of thousands of well-built homes, commercial buildings and clean vacant lots have morphed into an unprecedented amount of ugly blight.

There is no need to sugar-coat this calamity any longer. In fact, as is the case in so many areas of human challenge, the admission of reality in a complete, objective and unbiased manner is the first step on the road to recovery.

Make no mistake about it, this Task Force has taken on the mission to recommend a clear and detailed plan to fully and completely eradicate blight from the City of Detroit.

Just like removing only part of a malignant cancerous tumor is no real solution, removing only part or incremental amounts of blight from neighborhoods and the city as a whole is also no real solution. Because, like cancer, unless you remove the entire tumor, blight grows back.

This is a unique time in Detroit. There is a convergence of forces and timing on several fronts that is giving the city and all of those who live and/or work in it, a once in a millennium opportunity to get it right. This is a moment in time that is screaming for all of us to reject the divisive and destructive ways of the past. It is a moment that is calling on all of those who have the ability to positively and significantly affect the outcome to work together to do just that.

Downtown and midtown is experiencing the most productive period we have seen in recent memory, if not longer. There is hope and optimism in the air. However, without the neighborhoods of Detroit participating in the same kind of productive environment and without the residents in those neighborhoods feeling the same kind of hope, the positive momentum in downtown and midtown is bound to run out of steam.

Detroit is one city. You cannot divide the city into a section that beams with hope, optimism, and prospects of a bright future while the vast majority lives in hopelessness and despair.

The plan you read in these pages will inform you as it informed us. It will shock you in one sense but it will motivate you in another. Almost above all else, we have attempted to bring clarity to the massive challenge of blight. This clarity allowed us to recommend a set of detailed, comprehensive, well-articulated action-oriented strategies to address and remove all of the blight in Detroit as quickly as possible.

This monumental challenge needed the incredible work of many more than our small Task Force. Noble efforts from numerous people representing foundations, non-profits, private businesses, the city itself, the state, the feds, the field surveyors, and more worked tirelessly over these past nine months to help create and build this plan. Most of them will remain nameless but their work will never be forgotten and there is no 'thank you' that will do it justice.

We have just one ask of each of you that are reading these words: Please read the entire report. It's long, but as you turn the pages, we hope you will find the information is curated and packaged in a way that will maintain your interest. The more people who read this plan, the better chance we have of implementing the recommendations in it which are designed to make blight in Detroit something you can only see or read about in history books.

We believe that despite the enormity of Detroit's challenges, our city's best days are ahead of it.

The first major step on the path to this vision is the removal of the cancer of blight from our city. This plan gives us a detailed blueprint for how to take that first major step. This moment in time is calling on all of us to make the simple choice to work together unified in our determination to eliminate blight from the entire city of Detroit. It's a choice we must make. Failure is not an option.

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